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Betrayal and Resistance Theory Found in Othello

The tragedy of *Othello* follows a Venetian army group on their journey from Venice to Cyprus, and the betrayal of Iago to Othello as an act of defiance to Othello's leadership. This rebellion transpires quickly into the play and the group's journey, with Iago methodically disobeying all who he associates with while trying to ruin Othello's life. His disobedience is not without cause, however, as Iago believes Cassio should not have been promoted to Othello's lieutenant. With his coinciding distaste of both Cassio and Othello, Iago begins to operate against the way he is perceived of acting with the army. This disobedience is carefully executed, with Iago acting as his perceived self around those he wishes to betray, and acting as the villain around the select few individuals he can trust. Throughout the play, both Iago and Othello are products of resistance theory, as Iago's resistance to Othello births, in his mind, the idea that Cassio is the member of his group resisting his leadership. This resistance appears in three defining moments throughout the play, being the setup of a drunken Cassio, the brainwashing of Othello by Iago, and during the play's final scene where many characters are killed by the hands of another.

Iago's revenge towards Othello has been impending for some time prior to the play, and the promotion of Cassio to lieutenant finally leads to Iago preparing this revenge. Alaeddin Nahvi writes in his paper on the evils of Iago, stating "Iago's jealousy is actually the most critical issue in this play"(Nahvi 510). Taking place outside of the house of Brabantio (the father of

Othello's wife Desdemona) during Act 1, Scene 1, Iago speaks to his associate, Rodrigo, about his displeasure of working under Othello. "In following him, I follow but myself. Heaven is my judge, not I for love and duty, But seeming so for my peculiar end." (1.1.64-66). This line of dialogue foreshadows the obedience Iago is willing to display moving forward in his life.

Although he has to follow Othello's command, it's only done to benefit himself. Iago feels that nobody has any authority over himself, especially those in a position of power like Othello.

Iago's hate is further reiterated later in Act 1, Scene 3. In this monologue to the audience, Iago holds nothing back of his hate for his superior. "I hate the Moor, And it is thought abroad that 'twixt my sheets' Has done my office. I know not if 't be true, But I, for mere suspicion in that kind, Will do as if for surety"(1.3.429-433). It's now confirmed that Iago hates Othello, and with justification. Iago believes that his wife, Emilia, has committed adultery with Othello. Regardless of its merit, Iago believes it to be reason enough to ruin Othello's life. To garner revenge for Othello's wrongdoing, Iago feels that situation is one that relates to the biblical expression "an eye for an eye", or in the case of this play, a wife for a wife. Iago needs to hurt the wife of Othello to receive justice for the actions done to Emilia. To set in motion the chain of events which lead to Desdemona's death, Iago decides to make the recently promoted Cassio his puppet, using him as a way to torment Othello to his breaking point.

To begin his rebellion against Othello, Iago starts breaking down another man who is above his army rank, the newly appointed lieutenant Cassio. After the destruction of a Turkish fleet, and to commemorate the wedding of Othello and Desdemona, a celebration is held on Cyprus, consisting of plentiful amounts of food and wine. It is at this time, Iago's plan starts to take place, attempting to get Cassio drunk from the wine. It's made known to the audience that wine is a vice to Cassio, as he states "I have very poor and unhappy brains for

drinking.”(2.2.32-33) Iago still manages to pressure Cassio into drinking, regardless of his pleas to remain sober. After drinking, Cassio acts much less composed as he was, and is clearly intoxicated. After singing a number of songs together, Cassio and Iago share a brief conversation about the afterlife, where both men pray they go to heaven. The separation between Iago and Cassio’s class is brought up again, with Cassio stating “ The lieutenant is to be saved before the ancient.”(2.2.105-106) This point of class differentiation reinstalls the purpose of Iago's interaction with Cassio, reminding the audience of the resistance theory at play. To combat this statement, Iago begins to plant the seeds of Cassio being an alcoholic in people's minds, while using Roderigo as another puppet in his personal play. Cassio returns into the scene chasing Roderigo, threatening to “...beat the knave into a twiggish bottle.” (2.2.147) Montano, now aware of Cassio’s drunken state, begins to fight Cassio until Othello appears to discipline Cassio. David Wood writes that “Cassio's drunken brawling and subsequent demotion serves as the spur to the narrative of the play's events even as it provides an humoral template for Othello's destruction” (Wood). Iago's plan to ruin Othello is slowly, but surely starting to fall into place. To destroy and rebel against those of a higher class than himself, Iago brings these people down to his level, allowing him to simultaneously resist the governing powers of those who are meant to keep him in line, while subsequently raising his value in this military ecosystem.

Iago has now earned a greater amount of Othello's trust, while subsequently making Othello second guess himself for promoting a volatile Cassio. Cassio is also more susceptible for being Iago's pawn, which he subsequently makes use of to further attack Othello. Veronika Walker suggests that Cassio is now acting as a foil to Othello. “Cassio seems to represent the impishness of youth, the suave, debonair, and eye-catching gallantry that attracts lady folk to military men, whilst Othello represents the wisdom, experience, and backbone - both the brains

and brawn - of any army's foundation." (Walker). This disparity between Cassio and Othello is exactly what Iago has wanted, and he plans to further their relationship and disassemble Othello's wellbeing by abusing Cassio's romantic tendencies. In Act 3, Scene 1, Cassio talks to Iago's Wife, Emilia, about getting the chance to meet with Desdemona alone about making peace with Othello again. When Desdemona and Cassio are finally having their conversation in Act 3, Scene 3, Shakespeare foreshadows Desdemona's fate towards the end of one of her short monologues, with her stating that "For thy solicitor shall rather die Than give thy cause away." (3.3.29-30) Staying true to the nature of her character, Desdemona does meet her fate by Othello's hands at the end of the play, achieving the opposite of convincing Othello to re-promote Cassio to his former roll. After this conversation, Cassio leaves the room quickly once Othello approaches, not wanting him to know he spoke to Desdemona about the ongoing matter. Iago continues with his mission of destroying Othello by using Cassio, as Iago states "Ha! I like not that" (3.3.37) when he notices Cassio leaving the room currently occupied with Desdemona and Emilia. Othello is already frustrated, and to fuel this fire even more, Iago begins to start a ploy that Desdemona is having an affair with Cassio.

Othello originally committing adultery with Emilia is what leads to Iago wanting to overthrow the high-ranking Othello, and making Othello become an apparent victim of such a crime is the perfect way to get revenge. The love affair that Iago suggests is only thought to be true by Othello, but Othello's tunnel vision in the matter, and the repetition of Desdemona mentioning Cassio, is enough to make the matter seem real. Desdemona, for the remainder of the play, has a motif linked with her dialogue. On nearly every occasion that Desdemona and Othello talk, Desdemona always talks about Cassio. In Act 3, Scene 3, when Othello and Desdemona have a conversation in the presence of Iago and Emilia, Desdemona pleads to Othello that he

should meet again with Cassio from lines 55 to 99. In Act 4, Scene 1, Desdemona meets with Othello again and explains to Lodovico the dispute between Othello and Cassio, and how she “...would do much T' atone them, for the love I bear to Cassio.”(4.1.243-244) Othello hears this clearly, as in his mind the usage of the word “love” in her sentence has much stronger connotations than she really intends. This motif continues through the rest of the play, coming to a close before Desdemona's death, with Othello finally accusing her of adultery with Cassio. The relation between Resistance theory and this motif is due to both Iago and Cassio being responsible for disintegrating Othello's wellbeing. Before Cassio was demoted for fighting Montano, Othello held Cassio in high regards, even referring to Cassio as his friend (“The servants of the Duke and my lieutenant? The goodness of the night upon you, friends!”(1.2.37-39) Cassio, at this point, had no negative impact on Othello nor was there intent to harm him. Cassio was not of the same military rank at this time, yet he was close enough to make the difference between him and Othello negligible. It is only when Cassio is demoted to the same rank as Iago, that Cassio begins to be a burden to Othello. This speaks to resistance theory due to Othello being put through peril by a lower classed member of his army group. Even though Cassio never committed his accused act of adultery, Othello still feels that Cassio is actively trying to ruin his life since his demotion, therefore in his mind, seeing Cassio as an oppositionalist to himself, thus being another example of resistance theory in the play.

By the end of the play, Othello has finally been driven to lunacy by Iago. In Act 5, Scene 2, the play's finale, Othello is undeniably convinced that Desdemona has had an affair with Cassio, and promptly confronts her in their room. Moving backwards to Act 3, Scene 3, Othello starts to succumb to the reality of Desdemona having an affair, upon acceptance shouting the phrase “Oh, blood, blood, blood!”(3.3.504) Jennifer Feather views this statement to have much

significance throughout the remainder of the play, particularly how, around the sixteenth century, “‘blood’ dictates rank, culture, and identity”(Feather 240). Blood is referenced a number of times throughout the preceding of the play, but carries a number of meanings to each who speaks of it. For Othello, blood “encapsulates the tensions between these two modes of self-understanding—one that sees blood as stable and another that understands it as constantly in flux”(Feather 240). Believing that his own blood is in a state of flux, Othello feels that he must spill Desdemona's blood to neutralize his own. Again at Act 5, Scene 2, Othello finally smothers Desdemona after berating her with adultery accusations as she begs for her life. Desdemona does eventually die after Othello smothers her, but not until Emilia enters the room to her dying words of innocence. The events that occur around this murder also revolve around bloodshed. Iago finishes the killing of Rodrigo handed out by Cassio in the prior act, then Iago kills Emilia, followed by Othello stabbing the imprisoned Iago, and finally Othello ending his own life. All of the bloodshed was carried out in an act to rebalance one's own blood. Othello realized that the killing of Desdemona was in vain, thus leaving his essence still in turmoil. To finally heal himself, Othello decides he must end the life of the monster he has created, “I took by the throat the circumcised dog, And smote him, thus.”(5.2.407-408) Iago finally achieves his goal of overthrowing Othello, yet in the process is potentially mortally injured, and made a powerless prisoner with all members of society now above him instead of below. Cassio, the unfortunate pawn of the play, is the only character who receives justice, being the only successful executor of resistance theory after being involuntarily put in the position by Iago.

Othello is ultimately a tragedy which revolves around power struggle and revealing one's true self. Resistance theory plays an important role through the play, giving characters like Iago and Cassio justification for their actions and treatment. Iago was the initial character who desired

to overthrow Othello, believing he had had an affair with Emilia. Cassio also became involved in Resistance theory, in Othello's mind, as upon demotion Cassio was thought to have had an affair with Desdemona. Iago did succeed at ruining the life of Othello. He made Othello kill Desdemona, and eventually himself after realizing his wife was innocent all along. Iago was ultimately blinded by his resistance, however, as he ends up becoming a prisoner at the end of the play, and will presumably be put to death if not succumbing to his stab wound first. Instead, Cassio is the true victor of being involved in resistance theory. Iago, the man who turned Cassio into a pawn, has now ruined his own life, and is suffering the consequences for his actions, while Cassio gets promoted to the "lord governor" (5.5.423) after the death of Othello, his superior who almost ruined his life. Iago disobeyed all who were above him and lost everything, while Cassio stayed in line and was rewarded for staying noble throughout his suffering.

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